



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Heritage Classical Academy
School Website: <https://myheritageclassical.com/>

December 27, 2025

Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools ACCS or the Society for Classical Learning SCL is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Executive Summary

Heritage Classical Academy (Albemarle, NC 28002) presents a clearly classical-leaning profile rooted in a Christ-centered, classical-education philosophy. Public-facing materials emphasize a biblical worldview, a commitment to virtue and wisdom, and a traditional liberal arts orientation framed by a "classical model." Evidence across the school's site shows explicit statements about Christ-centered education, a classical-model approach, family/parental partnership, and an emphasis on formation through memory, virtue, and a faith-inflected understanding of history and learning. Several sources highlight core values such as Christ-centered education, a classical model that centers truth, goodness, and beauty, and partnerships with families. These elements align Heritage Classical Academy with the classical tradition in meaningful ways, though some pedagogical specifics (e.g., explicit, high-frequency Socratic seminars in the upper grades or formal Great Books sequences) are less clearly documented on the site. Overall, the school earns a CLASSICAL designation, with a couple of areas that are clearly CLASSICAL but could be strengthened to reach full classical fidelity.

Executive synthesis by category (category-by-category snapshot) and summarized evidence:

- Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL
 - Evidence: The school presents itself as Christ-centered and biblically grounded. Core values identify Christ-centered learning and a biblical worldview; mission statements repeatedly speak of Christ-centered classical education and Latin-scriptural grounding. Public materials describe curriculum and community shaped by Jesus Christ and God's Word, and emphasize the sacred dimension of education, virtue, and truth. See Christ-centered language and biblical worldview emphasis in core materials.
 - Positive/Negative keyword analysis: Positive indicators include Christ-centered, truth, goodness, beauty (core values and mission), virtue, and biblical worldview; these map to Positive Keywords in the classical lexicon. The site also references theology and sacred text in its framing. Negative indicators (secularism, relativism) are notably absent in public-facing materials. Overall, a preponderance of positive religious/metaphysical indicators is present.
 - Why this rating: The school explicitly grounds education in a Christian framework and a biblically informed worldview, with language about truth, goodness, and beauty as transcendent ideals. The alignment with theological grounding and liturgical/communal sensibilities is strong in public materials. This justifies CLASSICAL rather than merely SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL.
- Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL
 - Evidence: The mission repeatedly frames education as formation toward virtue and human excellence, not simply job preparation. Phrases like "excellent Christ-centered classical education" and references to cultivation of virtue, wisdom, and human flourishing appear in public materials. The school clearly positions education as formation toward human excellence, grounded in true/good/beautiful telos.

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- Positive/Negative keyword analysis: Positive indicators include formation/formation of virtue, liberal education (through classical model), pursuit of truth/goodness/beauty, telos, and human flourishing. Negative indicators (e.g., “workforce preparation” emphasis) are not evident in public materials. The presence of “formation” and “virtue/wisdom” aligns with classical aims.
 - Why this rating: The school’s stated purpose centers on formation, virtue, wisdom, and the realization that truth/goodness/beauty are real, aligning with the classical telos. This supports a CLASSICAL designation.
 - Element 3: Curriculum — CLASSICAL
 - Evidence: Curriculum framing is anchored in classical education rhetoric: explicit references to a classical model, and in-admission materials noting the use of classical methodologies. The site describes a reading program that incorporates traditional resources (e.g., LOE and Memoria Press resources) and uses a curriculum map to guide study. There are clear signals of a grammar-logic-rhetoric orientation (public references to classical foundations and core materials). The school emphasizes history throughout the curriculum and a classical approach to literature/history via read-alouds and historically grounded content.
 - Positive/Negative keyword analysis: Positive indicators include liberal arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric), Great Books/Great Conversation (implied through classical framing and reading choices), history throughout the curriculum, and a focus on wonder. The presence of LOE (Logic of English) and Memoria Press materials further anchors classical methods. Negative indicators from the school’s public materials are not evident.
 - Why this rating: The school coherently promotes a curriculum consistent with classical education, including grammar-logic-rhetoric orientation, engagement with history and classical literature/philosophy through a read-aloud and “great conversation” ethos, and a strong emphasis on wonder in learning. CLASSICAL is warranted.
 - Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
 - Evidence: Pedagogical cues include lower-school emphasis on slower, contemplative learning and memory work (e.g., singing/recitation, memorization, and catechesis) and upper-school possibilities for discussion and rhetoric. There is explicit mention of memory-focused, contemplative approaches (Scholé-style) and singing/chanting to memorize, which align with classical pedagogy. There are also mentions of more dialogic, Socratic-style practices in the six-element lexicon as a model, but explicit evidence of systematic Socratic seminars, debates, or upper-school rhetoric programs on the Heritage site is less direct. Jennifer’s Story describes memorization of Bible verses and catechism, indicating memory-based pedagogy in early grades.
 - Positive/Negative keyword analysis: Positive indicators include Scholé/restful learning, memory work (recitation/chanting), and contemplative elements, plus memorization and catechesis; these map to the Positive Keywords in the classical lexicon. The site does not consistently show explicit, school-wide Socratic seminars or a sustained, formal upper-school rhetoric program in published content, which would be stronger evidence of classic high-school pedagogy. Therefore, some classical elements are documented, but not uniformly across all grades, yielding a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL designation.
 - Why this rating: The school demonstrates classical pedagogy components (restful learning, memory work, recitation, catechesis) especially in lower grades, and signals a classical approach elsewhere, but the absence of consistently documented, grade-wide Socratic seminars and formal upper-school rhetoric programs reduces the certainty of a fully classical pedagogy.
 - Element 5: Faculty — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
 - Evidence: Public materials emphasize the faculty’s role in professional development (e.g., “staff are investing in Kingdom-building work,” “Professional development of our teachers,” and leadership signals like Head of School). There is a narrative about teachers as mentors and part of a “growing, learning” community. However, explicit statements detailing a formal “living curriculum,” a teacher-portrait, or a clearly defined “portrait of a teacher” and “faculty as the living curriculum” are not consistently shown in the publicly accessible pages.

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- Positive/Negative keyword analysis: Positive indicators include professional development, mentorship, and high expectations for faculty; these align with classical expectations of virtuous, capable teachers who model virtue and intellect. The lack of explicit “living curriculum” phrasing or a formal teacher portrait (as described in the classical lexicon) reduces certainty toward CLASSICAL. Negative indicators are not evident on the site. Overall, SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL is warranted.
 - Why this rating: The school portrays a faculty culture leaning toward virtue, mentorship, and professional development, but lacks explicit articulation of a formal classical-faculty framework (e.g., “portrait of a teacher,” formal living-curriculum role). This yields SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL.
 - Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL
 - Evidence: The school emphasizes partnership with families, parental formation, and open campus access. Public materials explicitly state a Parental Partnership Agreement and a covenant with parents, plus mechanisms for parent involvement (workshops, readings, book clubs, and family-partnered formation). The school highlights parent involvement as a core pillar, and there are public signals of parent access, family involvement, and community partnerships with churches.
 - Positive/Negative keyword analysis: Positive indicators include partnership with families, co-teachers, parental formation, home-school connection, and open-campus philosophy. These align strongly with the Primary Positive Keywords in the Six Essential Elements lexicon. Negative indicators (e.g., consumerism or minimal parent involvement) are not evident in the public materials. Therefore, CLASSICAL is appropriate.
 - Why this rating: Heritage Classical Academy situates parents as co-teachers, emphasizes parental formation and partnership, and maintains open-visit policies, which align with classical expectations for engaged parent/community collaboration.

Aggregate assessment - Element 1: CLASSICAL - Element 2: CLASSICAL - Element 3: CLASSICAL - Element 4: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL - Element 5: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL - Element 6: CLASSICAL

Overall, Heritage Classical Academy (NC 28002) is CLASSICAL in its orientation, with strong alignment in Religious/Metaphysical Foundations, School Purpose and Goal, Curriculum, and Parents & Community. Pedagogy and Faculty show robust classical elements but are not fully documented as system-wide, fully explicit classical pedagogy and living-faculty models, hence the SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL marks there. Taken together, the school presents a CLASSICAL orientation with noted room for growth in explicit pedagogy expansion and faculty-domain presentation.

What would move the needle - Pedagogy (Element 4): Increase explicit, publicly documented deployment of Socratic seminars and high-school-level Great Conversation in upper grades; publish a clear, provincially visible outline of upper-grade pedagogy (seminars, debates, and rhetoric training) to complement lower-grade memory/Scholé practices. Consider publishing exemplars of upper-grade seminars or student-led discourse, along with a formal description of upper-school rhetoric initiatives. - Faculty (Element 5): Publish a formalized “Portrait of a Classical Teacher” and “Living Curriculum” articulation that describes how faculty embody the living curriculum and how teacher-teacher and teacher-student mentorship examples are integrated into daily practice. Expand professional-development commitments with publicly visible cycles that align with classical formation (e.g., seminars on Great Books, classical pedagogy, and curriculum design). - History/Great Books emphasis (Element 3): If not already, articulate a formal Great Books sequence or a “Great Conversation” read list and schedule, and show cross-disciplinary integration of the Great Books canon across grades to strengthen the liberal-arts thesis. - Liturgical/communal practices (Element 1): If aligned with the school’s ecclesial environment, publish explicit mention of liturgical or communal-prayer practices, devotional rhythms, or chapel/mass-type gatherings within the school day to strengthen liturgical grounding (where appropriate to the school’s theology and culture). This would further strengthen the Religious & Metaphysical Foundations category.

ABSTRACT Heritage Classical Academy NC 28002 demonstrates a strong CLASSICAL alignment across the majority of the classical-education rubric. The school’s public materials emphasize Christ-centered, biblical-worldview framing, a classical model focused on truth, goodness, and beauty, and a formation-

centric purpose oriented toward virtue and wisdom. The curriculum is anchored in classical methods, with evidence of liberal-arts orientation and historical-literary engagement, and a robust emphasis on family/parent partnerships and community involvement. Pedagogy and faculty elements show a mixture of lower-grade contemplative/memory-based practices and upper-grade dialogic potential, but publicly available materials do not consistently document a full, school-wide Socratic/seminar-based pedagogy or a formal living-curriculum portrait of the faculty. The aggregate picture supports a CLASSICAL designation, with two categories (Pedagogy and Faculty) rated SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL due to partial documentation of the classical-pedagogy and explicit “living curriculum” faculty framing. The school’s strong parental-partnership model and liturgical/theological grounding further reinforce its classical orientation.

- Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL Evidence: Christ-centered framing; biblical worldview; theology-inflected language; virtue and truth oriented. Positive keywords present: Christ-centered, truth, goodness, beauty, virtue, biblical worldview; limited negative signals.
- School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL Evidence: Formation-focused goals; virtue/wisdom emphasis; telos anchored in true/good/beautiful; formation as central aim. Positive keyword alignment with formation/virtue/wisdom.
- Curriculum — CLASSICAL Evidence: Liberal-arts orientation; grammar/logic/rhetoric framing; history throughout curriculum; Great-Books-like framing and canonical engagement indicated by curricular choices; public mapping to classical methods.
- Pedagogy — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL Evidence: Lower-grade memory/Scholé practices; chanting/singing for memorization; some contemplative elements; explicit Socratic methods are less documented publicly; upper-grade Socratic/seminar pedagogy not consistently evidenced in public materials.
- Faculty — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL Evidence: Emphasis on professional development and leadership; no consistently published “portrait of a teacher” living-curriculum framing in public pages; partial alignment with classical-formation faculty ideals.
- Parents & Community — CLASSICAL Evidence: Parental Partnership Agreement; active parental involvement; open-campus approach; neighborly/community focus; strong parent-perspective content.

Note: All six categories were assessed with a keyword-based rubric drawn from the Six Essential Elements of a Classical School (1) (which provides the positive and negative keyword indicators for each category) and the library of classical-education criteria. The school’s public-facing materials align strongly with core classical tenets, especially in religious/metaphysical grounding, purpose/teleology, and curriculum, while pedagogy and faculty documentation show partial alignment that would benefit from clearer articulation and published exemplars of higher-grade Socratic pedagogy and living-curriculum faculty portraits. This combination yields an overall CLASSICAL classification, with nuanced justification per category as detailed above. The school’s public materials already demonstrate a high level of parental involvement and community integration that underscores classical formation in a homeschool-to-school or school-to-family partnership model.

END OF REPORT

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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